

LSU - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	National-contender underlying quality with a defense-first floor, but more implementation risk than the No. 10 SP+ rank alone implies.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 11 (988 points) · SEC media 5th (1,961 points; 2 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 10
Returning production	61% (No. 32) overall · Off. 61% (No. 42) · Def. 60% (No. 37)
Primer power rating	+20.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.5 wins · most likely 9-3
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC Lane Kiffin and OC Charlie Weis Jr. build around QB Sam Leavitt, a deep skill group and TE Trey'Dez Green, while DC Blake Baker retains a talented defense. Cohesion is the main question on a newcomer-heavy roster.

Bottom line: LSU has playoff-caliber quality and a defense that can carry early transition, but the new offense, right-side OL and specialists must stabilize to fully realize the top-10 model rating.

Beats expectations if: QB Sam Leavitt adds efficient explosiveness, OT Jordan Seaton and OL Josh Moore anchor a settled line, and DC Blake Baker's reload preserves elite defensive efficiency.

Disappoints if: The new offense remains disjointed, explosiveness and negative-play problems persist, and defensive turnover outweighs the talent of the reload.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB/health clarity:** QB Sam Leavitt is the current QB1, Husan Longstreet the current QB2, and Leavitt says he is 100% recovered from the foot injury that limited his spring.
- 2 ★ TE Trey'Dez Green:** TE Trey'Dez Green is the roster's strongest recognition signal: AP/Walter Camp first team, first-team All-SEC recognition and Mackey/Walter Camp Player of the Year watch context.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was legitimately strong (opponent-adjusted No. 15; defensive EPA/play allowed No. 8), while the offense was among the least explosive teams in FBS (No. 134).
- 4 Offensive line:** LSU has major new starters/transfers across QB, WR, OL, edge and secondary, so the talent level is high but newcomer dependence on both sides materially lowers evaluation confidence.
- 5 ? Defensive availability:** LB Junior Tuihalamaka was reported as committed to LSU, but his eligibility/current roster membership remains unresolved; he is not counted as settled 2026 depth.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (3-5 SEC)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	22.8 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	333.5 YPG	● Poor
Rush offense	104.0 YPG · 3.6 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	6.74 YPA · 20 TD / 7 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	37.0%	● Below average
Scoring defense	19.8 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	328.7 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	124.1 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	204.6 YPG · 6.43 YPA · 14 TD allowed	● Very good

LSU's 7-6 record hid a sharp split: a very good defense kept games manageable, while a weak rushing attack and poor total offense left the offense unable to carry its share.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-0.50 · No. 66	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.010 · No. 71	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	39.5% · No. 107	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	8.2% · No. 134	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	18.0% · No. 118	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.12 · No. 15	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.175 · No. 8	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	38.3% · No. 33	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.8% · No. 65	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	16.6% · No. 44	● Good / above average

Advanced-stat read: The 2025 profile was unusually clean analytically: defense was genuinely high-end, while offense was the problem. Opponent-adjusted defense (No.15) and defensive EPA/play allowed (No.8) support the defense-first floor.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Lane Kiffin - new from Ole Miss HC	● ↑ Brings a proven offensive identity, but Year 1 introduces a full-program transition.
OC / play-caller	◆ Charlie Weis Jr. - new from Ole Miss OC/QBs; confirmed 2026 LSU play-caller from booth	● ↑ Transition with upside; caller established
DC	Blake Baker - returning in same role	● ↔ Retaining Baker preserves defensive scheme leadership through the head-coach transition.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Sam Leavitt	Arizona State	● ↔ Current QB1 with Maxwell recognition and a resolved preseason health outlook; not treated as a proven upgrade over the departed veteran.
◆ OT Jordan Seaton	Colorado	● ↑ Immediate LT anchor with national/SEC recognition and a first-unit role.
◆ WR Jayce Brown	Kansas State	● ↔ First-unit/top-rotation receiver in a deep rebuilt room.
◆ WR Eugene Wilson III	Florida	● ↔ Material rotation/starting-role candidate; exact top-three ordering remains unsettled.

Out	To	Loss
QB Garrett Nussmeier	NFL (Kansas City), Round 7, No. 249	● ↓ Starting-QB experience leaves, increasing transition risk despite QB Sam Leavitt’s arrival.
WR Zavion Thomas	NFL (Chicago), Round 3, No. 89	● ↓ Material receiving/return talent departs.
WR Barion Brown	NFL (New Orleans), Round 6, No. 190	● ↓ Another material WR departure increases reliance on the new rotation.
OL Josh Thompson	NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful offensive-line experience departs via confirmed UDFA signing.

Offensive net: ● ↑ modest upgrade in ceiling, with substantial cohesion risk

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Princewill Umanmielen	Ole Miss	● ↑ First-team All-SEC/Bednarik recognition and a projected starting role make him an impact addition.
◆ EDGE Jordan Ross	Tennessee	● ↔ Projected starting edge/top rotation adds immediate front-line talent.
◆ S Faheem Delane	Ohio State	● ↑ High-confidence projected starting safety in the rebuilt back end.
◆ S Ty Benefield	Boise State	● ↑ Expected starter with AP/SEC preseason recognition.

Out	To	Loss
CB Mansoor Delane	NFL (Kansas City), Round 1, No. 6	● ↓ First-round corner departure is a major secondary loss.
S A.J. Haulcy	NFL (Indianapolis), Round 3, No. 78	● ↓ Day-two safety departure removes another high-value back-end piece.
LB Harold Perkins Jr.	NFL (Atlanta), Round 6, No. 215	● ↓ High-leverage front-seven talent departs for the NFL.

Defensive net: ● ↔ high-end reload rather than clean continuity

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	New Kiffin/Weis structure around QB Sam Leavitt, deep skill talent and TE Trey'Dez Green.	Multiple high-end skill answers with OT Jordan Seaton and OL Josh Moore as line anchors.	Cohesion, right-side OL and restoring explosiveness after a No. 134 rate in 2025.
Defense	DC Blake Baker continuity with a heavily reloaded front seven and secondary.	Elite 2025 EPA suppression plus high-end returning and transfer talent.	Replacing multiple NFL departures without losing communication or depth.
Special teams	Elite punting signal, unsettled placekicking.	P Grant Chadwick is a recognized returning punter/holder.	Kicker remains a competition after K Damian Ramos departs.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	Medium	QB Sam Leavitt raises the ceiling but still replaces veteran QB Garrett Nussmeier.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium	RB Dilin Jones leads a talented but reworked backfield.
WR	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	WR Jayce Brown and other newcomers replenish a room losing WR Zavion Thomas and WR Barion Brown.
TE	● A	● ↑	High	TE Trey'Dez Green is the offense's elite returning centerpiece.
OL	● B+	● ↑	Medium	OT Jordan Seaton anchors a talented line that still must settle the right side.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	EDGE Princewill Umanmielen leads a high-end reload after major departures.
LB	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Whit Weeks anchors a strong returning second level.
Secondary	● A-	● ↔	Medium	CB DJ Pickett and S Ty Benefield headline a talented but rebuilt back end.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	P Grant Chadwick is a first-team SEC/Ray Guy-recognized returning punter/holder.
Coaching	● A-	● ↑	Medium	HC Lane Kiffin and OC Charlie Weis Jr. raise offensive upside while DC Blake Baker preserves continuity.
Overall	● A	● ↑	Medium-low	National-contender quality with a defense-first floor, but more implementation risk than the No. 10 SP+ rank implies.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Trey'Dez Green	TE	● National star / elite tight end	AP first team · Walter Camp first team · SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Mackey · Walter Camp POY	The strongest returning offensive centerpiece and a mismatch anchor for a new offense.
◆ Princewill Umanmielen (TR: Ole Miss)	EDGE	● National-impact edge	SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Bednarik	Projected starting edge and the most decorated front-line addition.
Whit Weeks	LB	● National-impact linebacker	SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Bednarik · Butkus	Returning linebacker anchor in Baker's defense.
◆ Jordan Seaton (TR: Colorado)	OT	● National-level offensive tackle	AP second team · Walter Camp second team · SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Outland	High-confidence left-tackle anchor for a line that still has right-side questions.
Grant Chadwick	P	● National specialist	SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team · Ray Guy	Stabilizes punting/holding while placekicker is replaced.
◆ Sam Leavitt (TR: Arizona State)	QB	● High-upside Power 4 starter	Maxwell	Current QB1, reportedly 100% recovered from the prior foot injury, and the largest single variable in converting the 2025 offense into a contender-level unit.
DJ Pickett	CB	● High-end conference corner	SEC Coaches second team · SEC Media second team · Bednarik	Projected starting corner in a talented but heavily rebuilt secondary.
◆ Ty Benefield (TR: Boise State)	S	● High-end conference safety	AP second team · SEC Coaches third team · SEC Media second team	High-confidence projected starter who helps offset major NFL departures in the secondary.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Difficult contender schedule; the top-end games are concentrated enough that LSU can be very good and still take multiple losses.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 19
Hardest stretch	Alabama → Texas → at Tennessee (Nov. 7-21), immediately after the Oct. 31 bye
Swing games	at Ole Miss, Texas A&M, at Auburn, Alabama, Texas, at Tennessee
Advantage	Two non-Power home games are embedded before conference-heavy stretches, and the only bye comes immediately before the Alabama/Texas/Tennessee run.
Expected	8.5 wins · most likely 9-3
Floor / ceiling	7-5 / 11-1

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	LSU should be priced closer to its top-10 model/talent profile than its 7-6 record; value depends on how much seamless transition is assumed.
Back them when	Opponents are vulnerable to LSU's high-end defense and the price does not require the new offense to be fully mature.
Fade/pass when	Premium pricing assumes immediate offensive explosiveness, settled right-side OL or proven placekicking.
Key monitor	Right-side OL, RB/WR distribution, kicker competition, LB Junior Tuihalamaka status, late injuries/availability
Week 1 baseline	LSU -9.5 vs. Clemson · rating-only baseline; LSU primer +20.5 minus Clemson primer +13.0 plus 2.0 default home field; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: LSU -10.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

LSU enters 2026 with a top-10 model profile, a proven defensive floor and major offensive upside under HC Lane Kiffin and OC Charlie Weis Jr. QB Sam Leavitt and OT Jordan Seaton headline a high-end but newcomer-heavy offense.

The playoff case depends less on raw talent than on fast cohesion: settle the right side of the OL, find reliable placekicking and preserve DC Blake Baker's defensive efficiency. Nine wins is the most likely outcome on a hard schedule.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [camp update](#) · [roster roles](#) · [coaching](#) · [departures](#) · [current update](#) · [current update 2](#) · [Leavitt health update](#)

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